

The Sokovia Problem: Why Morality Cannot Be Centralized

What Captain America understood about ethics boards that bioethicists don't.

By Sage Clokey

The Accords

In *Captain America: Civil War*, the United Nations drafts the Sokovia Accords — a legal framework to place the Avengers under governmental oversight.

The justification is collateral damage. Sokovia leveled. Lagos in flames. Innocent people dead in the wake of extraordinary individuals acting on their own judgment. The world watches the footage and demands control. A panel. A committee. A board that decides when the Avengers may act, where they may go, and what they may do.

Steve Rogers refuses to sign.

┆ *“The safest hands are still our own.”*

Tony Stark pushes back. Accountability matters, he says. People died.

And Rogers doesn't deny it. He carries it. But he sees something Stark doesn't — or won't. The question is not whether mistakes were made. The question is who you trust to do better next time. The individual conscience, or the institution.

Rogers answers the only way he can:

“What if there’s somewhere we need to go and they won’t let us? What if there’s somewhere we don’t want to go and they make us?”

That is not arrogance. It is the recognition of something most people feel but few are willing to say out loud: a centralized authority that controls moral action does not eliminate evil. It merely relocates it — and makes it harder to resist.

The Arsonist Becomes the Fire Chief

Here is the detail the Accords’ defenders never address.

Sokovia was destroyed by Ultron. And Ultron was not the product of rogue individuals acting without oversight. Ultron emerged from the same ecosystem of institutional power — SHIELD, Hydra nested inside SHIELD, government-funded weapons programs, intelligence agencies operating in the dark.

The entire infrastructure that enabled the catastrophe was institutional. The system didn’t fail to prevent the disaster. The system *produced* it. And then the system turned around and demanded the authority to regulate the people who tried to stop it.

The pattern is not unique to fiction. It is, in fact, the defining pattern of centralized moral authority throughout history.

Tuskegee (1932-1972). The United States Public Health Service — a government institution — deliberately withheld syphilis treatment from Black men for forty years. Not rogue scientists. The institution itself, conducting the experiment by design.

Forced Sterilization (1907-1970s). Over sixty thousand Americans were forcibly sterilized under state laws upheld by the Supreme Court, where Justice Oliver Wendell Holmes wrote in *Buck v. Bell* that “three generations of imbeciles are enough.” The government did not fail to regulate. The government was the perpetrator.

Unit 731 (1937-1945). The Imperial Japanese Army ran biological warfare experiments on living prisoners — under full state authority and institutional funding.

Operation Paperclip (1945-1959). After the war, the United States didn’t prosecute those scientists. It recruited them. Nazi researchers who had conducted concentration camp experiments were brought into American labs, given security clearances and government salaries. The institution didn’t punish the evil. It hired it.

MKUltra (1953-1973). The CIA conducted illegal mind-control experiments on unwitting American citizens. Authorized at the highest levels. Covered up for decades.

Every case follows the same arc. The institution commits the atrocity, then positions itself as the necessary guardian against future atrocities. The arsonist becomes the fire chief. And anyone who questions the arrangement is told they are being irresponsible.

Rogers sees it for what it is. He is not claiming to be perfect. He is claiming something simpler and more radical: that an imperfect free person acting on conscience is less dangerous than an imperfect institution acting on power.

The Ethics Board Problem

Now bring this to the present.

In bioethics — particularly in fields like brain organoid research, genetic engineering, and human subjects experimentation — the standard answer to moral complexity is the ethics board. The Institutional Review Board. The oversight committee. The regulatory body.

The assumption is always the same: individuals cannot be trusted with moral judgment, so we must centralize that judgment in a panel of appointed experts operating under institutional authority.

But ask the question Captain America asks. *Who sits on that board?*

People appointed by the same institutions with histories of moral catastrophe. People funded by the same grant structures that incentivize compliance over conscience. People whose careers depend on not disrupting the institutional order that employs them.

The ethics board does not eliminate bias. It institutionalizes bias and gives it the authority of consensus.

A researcher who refuses to comply with an ethics board is labeled reckless. An ethics board that fails to prevent harm is labeled “imperfect but necessary.” The individual bears full accountability. The institution bears none.

That is not oversight. That is the consolidation of moral authority into the hands of the very structures least equipped to wield it honestly.

Every Person a Moral Node

There is another architecture.

One that does not concentrate moral authority but distributes it. One that does not ask “who should be in charge of ethics?” but instead recognizes that every person already is.

Think of it like a network. Not a hierarchy with a central server issuing commands, but a distributed system — every node processing, every node accountable, every node sovereign.

In this architecture, every researcher is a moral agent. Not a subordinate waiting for a committee's permission slip, but a person who must look at what they are doing and decide, on their own conscience, whether it is right.

Every community is a check — not through legal coercion, but through reputation, trust, and the natural consequences of acting in ways that violate the moral intuitions of the people around you.

And every individual receives their moral instructions not from a board, not from a government, not from an institution, but from something higher. Call it God. Call it the Creator. Call it the moral law written into the structure of reality itself.

The source of moral authority is not human bureaucracy. It is transcendent. It precedes the institution and will outlast it.

This is the architecture Steve Rogers lives by. He does not claim to be his own highest authority. He submits to something — to principle, to the bone-deep conviction that some things are right and some things are wrong and no vote of a panel can make it otherwise.

But that something is not the UN. It is not a committee. It is the still, stubborn knowledge held at the level of the individual soul.

The Creator's Design Language

This is not just philosophy. The architecture of creation itself confirms it.

A living organism is not a top-down command structure. It is a distributed network — trillions of cells, each carrying the full genome, each making local decisions, each responding to signals from its neighbors.

There is no central planning committee in the body telling the liver what to do and the heart when to beat. There is a shared code — DNA — and each cell reads that code and acts on it in its own context.

The immune system does not wait for approval from a board. It recognizes a threat and it responds. If it waited for centralized authorization, you would die of infection before the memo cleared committee review.

This is the Creator's design language: **distributed intelligence, local moral agency, shared foundational code.**

The whole organism thrives not because a central authority manages every cell, but because every cell carries the instructions within itself and has the freedom to act on them.

The Sokovia Accords are the biological equivalent of telling the immune system it needs UN approval before it can fight a virus. It sounds reasonable in a press conference. In practice, it kills the organism.

The Safest Hands

The argument for centralized ethics boards rests on a premise that feels intuitive but collapses under the weight of every century that has tested it: that concentrating moral authority in institutions makes the world safer.

History says otherwise. Fiction illuminates what history proves.

Captain America does not reject accountability. He rejects the lie that accountability flows downward from institutions to individuals.

True accountability flows upward — from each person to the moral law above them — and outward — from each person to the people beside them. It is not imposed. It is chosen. It is not enforced from the top down. It is grown from within.

Every person is a node. Every conscience is sovereign. Every soul answers to the Creator, not the committee.

The safest hands are still our own.

“The price of freedom is high. It always has been. And it’s a price I’m willing to pay.”

The Sokovia Problem is part of the Sagent Creed — the ongoing work of Sage Clokey on moral independence, distributed architecture, and the refusal to cede conscience to any institution that claims authority it has not earned and cannot be trusted to wield.